Your Cruel Device

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50065945.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Grizzlor (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Season 4 AU, Chemical Weapons, Perfuma uses Chemical Warfare, Geneva Convention, Hurt

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2023-09-13 Words: 2,371 Chapters: 1/1

Your Cruel Device

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50065945.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Grizzlor (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Season 4 AU, Chemical Weapons, Perfuma uses Chemical Warfare, Geneva Convention, Hurt

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2023-09-13 Words: 2,371 Chapters: 1/1

Your Cruel Device

by Kurt_Angles_Tailbone

Summary

Perfuma uses her magic to create chemical weapons. The Horde calls for a conference on the rules of warfare on Etheria.

Season 4 AU-esque.

Notes

This is part of a larger canon divergence I haven't bothered to write out yet.

At the end of season 3, Hordak is dead, Angella is still queen and Catra has taken over as commander of the Horde. Though there was an attempt at peace, territorial disputes made the Horde and the Princess Alliance unable to reach any agreement.

The Brightmoon labourers had been hard at work since the early morning hours to construct the wooden podium and banked benches surrounding it. Banners of each kingdom stood arrayed in a crescent on one side of the clearing: Brightmoon, Mystacor, the Kingdom of Snows, Plumeria and Salineas; more than half the kingdoms of Etheria, forming the Princess Alliance. The other side, reserved for the Horde's congregation, stood deserted.

"I swear, if she's late to a conference she *herself* called for, I'm teleporting us all out of here," Glimmer seethed.

"What, everyone?" Bow joked.

"Watch me!" Glimmer hissed, whirling on the young man.

"I'm sure Catra will come," Adora mumbled without conviction, anxiously watching the western treeline. "She's never missed one before, has she?"

"There's only ever *been* one," Glimmer retorted hotly, storming away to yell at some hapless guards.

"Don't mind her. It's all just been very stressful, lately."

Adora heaved out a long breath. She hadn't even registered Glimmer's anger all that much. The mere thought of Catra's (probably) imminent arrival left her scattered and confused.

Ever since her ascension to leadership over the Horde, the war had taken a turn for the worse for the Princess Alliance. They had started losing, and badly at that. Each battle won by She-ra's presence left a dozen others as losses, and the losses were more keenly felt. The casualties, the missing faces in the barracks, the expanding cemetaries... the sparing happiness she felt upon first joining the Princess Alliance and coming to know a wider, more colourful world was slowly but surely ebbing away.

She stopped having fun.

And she was starting to grow tired, running herself ragged and sleepless. But what choice was there? The question rolled around in her head as she watched the benches gradually start to fill up with an audience. Soldiers, citizens, sailors from the outer ports and even thickly-garbed denizens of the Crimson Wastes, everyone was keen to see where this would lead, and how much more misery the world was due. But what choice did she have?

What choice did She-ra really have?

"The Horde! The Horde is here!"

Adora was drawn from her spiraling thoughts by a cry taken up around the clearing. Sure enough, a sizeable congregation of skiff-mounted soldiers trailed by a few transports emerged, heralded by the roar of their engines. At their head…

Relief, sadness, pity, and just a big fucking hole in her stomach. It was all she felt as Catra leapt off the leading skiff. They locked eyes, Adora's stomach knotted up, and then Catra looked away, grim and stony-faced. She looked tired too, yet there was a calculated determination underneath, vicious and intense. The new face of the most powerful military force in the world.

"Your majesty," her raspy voice rang out across the clearing, dripping with sarcasm. "My earnest apologies for the delay. The Whispering Woods have never been easy on us."

Queen Angella dislodged herself from her gaggle of dignitaries and sycophants, sweeping an imperial gaze over the Horde forces. Catra didn't shift an inch.

"We've received your invitation and are ready to proceed, Commander. How much longer will you have us wait?"

Catra's tail swished once. She was enjoying herself.

At least someone is, Adora thought.

"Oh, not much longer at all."

True to her word, the Horde side of the camp sprang up in the blink of an eye. Entrapta's technology had evidently progressed far enough that their tents and banners seemed to rise up on their own volition, while the uniformed soldiers unpacked with a bustling efficiency. Adora noted that the majority of them joined the audience in the wooden gallery while the rest took up ceremonial position by the podium or around camp.

Before long, the Horde's wings blew proudly in the wind, joined by Dryl's heraldry. *Hordak's wings*, came an unbidden thought, even though the Lord of the Horde was long dead and gone.

The Princess Alliance arranged themselves around the long table on the podium. Queen Angella sat at the head, flanked by Glimmer on one side and Adora on the other. Adora had even transformed into She-ra for the occassion. Being in She-ra's form was the absolute last thing she wanted, but Glimmer had insisted on it, and who was Adora to say no? It just never came easy to her.

Catra sat on the other side, surrounded by her Force Captains. Scorpia, Grizzlor, Octavia, Cobalt, Leech and the rest. There were a few faces Adora didn't recognise, like the lizard man who introduced himself as Tung Lashor (*Seriously?*).

When all were sat down, a wizened bull-man from Mystacor tapped his staff twice on the podium, producing a dull ringing sound alike a gong which silenced the benches.

"On behalf of the Watchers and Intermediaries of Mystacor's People…" he began in a droning rumble. Catra snorted, and Adora was suddenly entirely preoccupied with finding out the reason why. "I welcome you to the Second Whispering Woods Conference. Representing the Princess Alliance, we have… hrum… Queen Angella of Brightmoon, She-ra of the Crystal Castle... Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon, Princess Perfuma of Plumeria, Princess…"

Adora zoned out much of the ceremonial bluff, staring right at Catra. Part of her wished her old friend would look back at her, part of her was anxious not to get caught. She looked as tired as Adora felt, yes, and with that interminable viciousness beneath, true, but there was something about her. She looked so *gaunt*, her cheeks slightly sunken in, her brown fur a little paler in several patches, and painfully thin.

"…Princess Scorpia of Horror Hall, and Lord Catra of the Fright Zone—"

"*Commander* Catra," one of her Force Captains hissed, immediately joined by rumbles of support from the Horde side of the audience. Adora didn't understand why it mattered. She wished she did.

"Apologies. Commander Catra of the Fright Zone. Now, let the Second Whispering Woods Conference…" he drew the words out with a self-important air, and let his staff ring out with a final tap. "…commence."

Silence followed. It didn't last.

"*Well?*" sounded Glimmer, already exasperated. "You called us here. Why don't you tell us what it is you want?"

"Easy, Sparkles." Catra drawled, "We've got the entire day ahead of us."

"Maybe if you showed up on TIME…"

"Glimmer." Angella silenced her daughter with a raised hand, and then settled her piercing stare on Catra. Again, she didn't even so much as twitch. "Commander Catra. Last time we met here we were regrettably unable to come to terms for a peace treaty. Have circumstances changed?"

"Oh no, not in the slightest," Catra said, leaning back in her chair. "You may consider any terms raised during the previous conference to be set in the stone."

“Then why did you…” Adora began, though her own voice felt faint and weak on her own ears. Talking to Catra suddenly felt like such a challenge, when the magicat’s blue-and-yellow eyed stare landed on her. There was a sudden tightness to Catra’s jaw. Perhaps she hadn’t expected it either.

“Then WHY did you call us here?” Adora could rely on Glimmer to mount the question with twice the fury.

“I thought we might establish some rules. Some gentleman’s rules of warfare, if you will.”

“Elaborate,” Queen Angella spoke in an icy tone.

“You’ll recall a skirmish nineteen days ago on the border of Dryll which saw the deployment of a hitherto unknown chemical weapon of, presumably, Plumerian design. I say Plumerian design, because *fourteen* days ago this agent saw much more extensive deployment in your successful effort to reclaim Thaymor. Clashing with Plumeria's forces, Horde casualties numbered around seven-hundred.”

“764, to be exact,” Scorpia chimed in, brooding over her pincers.

Adora felt a shiver run down her spine. She had been part of the assault on Thaymor. She recalled the way the Horde soldiers had clawed at their helmets in an effort to get them off, how removing them revealed their skin beneath bubbling and sizzling and turning a horrid blotchy yellow underneath.

She recalled the way their eyes just… *rolled out of their sockets*. How they crawled, screaming until their voices deteriorated into animalistic gurgling. Death came slow, but as a certainty.

She looked aside at Plumeria, as several other Princesses did. It was her handiwork after all; fungal toxins released in the air to beautifully efficient, horrifying destructive effects. She had turned pale and silent, staring at the table.

"For what survivors there were, not even Entrapta could find a cure. Another sixty-three caught by the agent on the outskirts of town died in the medical bay over the course of the next forty-eight hours." Catra leaned forward somewhat, tapping one of her claws against the wood. "Each and every one of them spent their last moments in excruciating pain."

Scorpia chimed in again, reading from her papers. "The Horde, in its entirety, calls for the complete ban on this chemical weapon, as well as any future weapon of chemical and biological variety on any and all battlefield to come." She gave a signal, and one of the attendants ferried the document to the Princess Alliance side of the table.

"You want us to… stop using a weapon which has pretty much guaranteed victory in any battle we've used it in, and probably any future ones as well, by the sounds of your motion," Glimmer looked between the document and the Horde party, only slightly incredulous.

Scorpia had the grace to smile, and it looked strangely genuine. "Yep! That is correct."

There was another brief silence.

"So… I feel like I'm missing something here," came Mermista's bored tone. "*Why* would we want to stop using this weapon? I mean, sure," and her voice hitched here, just a tad, "It's… kinda horrific, but…"

"That is exactly why. We've found the weapon to be an inhumane tool in warfare. Barring all the details with which our Commander just graced you with, which, woo boy! Is kinda plenty reason already, Thaymor seems to have become barren land even after your clean-up operation, and you seem rather unwilling to occupy the town you've taken."

"It's proven rather… difficult to remove the toxins from the earth and air," Perfuma seemed to force the words through her teeth,

still looking at the table. "But not impossible. It'll take us some time to…"

"This is ridiculous. If you want us to stop using this agent, all you have to do is give us your *unconditional fucking surrender*," Glimmer cut in harshly, hands planted on the table.

"Soldiers die," Bow said, though Adora couldn't trace any conviction in his voice. "That's just the way it is."

"Agree with ya there, Arrow Boy." Catra spoke up again, affecting nonchalance as she leaned back in her seat again. "But maybe you should've listened more closely. As our terms go, this weapon would be banned from usage for *both* sides. Us included."

Glimmer gave an incredulous laugh even as Perfuma finally looked up in horror. "*Both* sides? And how do you suppose you'll replicate this without Perfuma's magic?"

"I'll forgive you for forgetting about her, *again*, since we didn't bring her along, but Entrapta's been hard at work."

At the sound of her name, a chilling hush descended over the Princess Alliance.

"You've…" Perfuma began haltingly.

"Oh, that's rich. And we're expected to *believe* you?" Glimmer said.

"Glimmer, they might be speaking the truth. Entrapta…"

"We can't trust them, Bow! We've finally got something to take the Horde down, *of course* they would want to make it stop," Glimmer glowered back at the Horde congregation. "But, too bad for *you*, that's not happening."

Catra upnodded at one of her Force Captains, Grizzlor, who pulled something from underneath the table and slid it across, right in

front of Queen Angella. The guards behind her stirred, and Adora herself tensed.

It was a rectangular metal case. Adora glanced at Catra, who caught her eye, and then reached out to click the thing open. Inside was a long shell. Trepidation ran up and down Adora's arms, giving her goosebumps.

"Is this…?"

"Perfuma, can you…" Bow passed the shell along to Perfuma, who took it in trembling hands. She closed her eyes.

She gasped. Adora felt herself cringe.

"It's true. They… they've…"

"It took Entrapta a while to engineer a replicate of your new tool, Flower Princess, but of course she managed it. We're talking about Entrapta, after all. We've enough of these shells to bathe a dozen Thaymors in gas. We could. I sorely want to, after seeing what you did to my men, after seeing what you did to…"

She trailed off, but another rumble had started to swell in the ranks of the Horde, fueled by their leader's emotion. Octavia sneered, all but growling the words out. "But Kyle and Scorpia convinced her not to."

"You can keep the shell, Flower Princess." Catra spoke up again, recomposed, rigid and with a devilish smirk tugging at the corner of her mouth. "Think of it as a little souvenir. Your very own contribution to the art of warfare."

Perfuma had now gone deathly pale, trembling in her seat. Frosta reached out, laying a hand on the other princess' shoulder. Glimmer opened her mouth for an unfortunate choice of words, no doubt, and Adora was thankful when she heard Angella speak first.

"Very well. I think… we can agree on the ban. And any future weapons of similar fashion."

Catra clapped her hands together, leaning her elbows on the table. "Great! Glad we could straighten that out. Shouldn't let a little war get in the way of courtesy, mhm?"

"We've some other matters to bring to the table. Prisoner exchanges, the recovery of fallen soldiers from the recent clash near the Kingdom of Snows…"

Adora tuned Scorpia's voice out, sitting back in the chair as she watched Catra. As Scorpia took the stage entirely, she watched for the little tells in Catra's body language. The flick of her ears, the way her tailed swished and curled.

But she just looked tired. Tired, and not entirely there.

They caught each other's eye in the afternoon break, and Catra didn't look at her for the rest of the day.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!